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Lint exhaust duct cleaning tool and method for cleaning a clothes dryer ventilation system

Abstract

A duct cleaning appliance is adapted for cleaning a ventilation system of a clothes dryer. The duct cleaning appliance includes a hollow duct cleaning tool operatively connected at an open proximal end to a portable airstream appliance adapted for generating a pressurized airflow. An open distal end of the duct cleaning tool is placed over a screen housing opening of the clothes dryer, such that the distal end closely engages the clothes dryer to operatively air-seal the screen housing opening. The portable airstream appliance is then activated to evacuate lint and debris collected inside the ductwork of the ventilation system.

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Background/Summary

TECHNICAL FIELD AND BACKGROUND OF THE DISCLOSURE

(1) The present disclosure relates broadly and generally to a dryer duct cleaning tool and method for cleaning a clothes dryer ventilation system.

(2) Clothes dryers cause thousands of house fires per year worldwide, and many of those are caused by excess lint collected in ductwork. According to Consumer Reports® and other publications, your clothes dryer is much more likely to catch on fire because of lint buildup than because of an electrical problem. In the span of a year or less, the lint build up can cause a blockage in the dryer ventilation system. This not only creates a fire hazard, but can lead longer drying times and wasted energy. Because of this, fire departments generally recommend that the dryer ventilation system be properly cleaned at least once a year.

SUMMARY OF EXEMPLARY EMBODIMENTS

(3) Various exemplary embodiments of the present disclosure are described below. Use of the term “exemplary” means illustrative or by way of example only, and any reference herein to “the invention” is not intended to restrict or limit the invention to exact features or steps of any one or more of the exemplary embodiments disclosed in the present specification. References to “exemplary embodiment,” “one embodiment,” “an embodiment,” “various embodiments,” and the

like, may indicate that the embodiment(s) of the invention so described may include a particular feature, structure, or characteristic, but not every embodiment necessarily includes the particular feature, structure, or characteristic. Further, repeated use of the phrase “in one embodiment,” or “in an exemplary embodiment,” do not necessarily refer to the same embodiment, although they may. (4) It is also noted that terms like “preferably”, “commonly”, and “typically” are not utilized herein to limit the scope of the claimed invention or to imply that certain features are critical, essential, or even important to the structure or function of the claimed invention. Rather, these terms are merely intended to highlight alternative or additional features that may or may not be utilized in a particular embodiment of the present invention.

(5) According to one exemplary embodiment, the present disclosure comprises a method for cleaning a ventilation system of a clothes dryer. The ventilation system includes ductwork communicating with a lint exhaust of the clothes dryer and extending to a remote discharge location. The method comprises operatively connecting an open proximal end of a hollow duct cleaning tool to a portable airstream appliance adapted for generating a pressurized airflow. A lint screen is first removed from a screen housing opening at the lint exhaust of the clothes dryer. An open distal end of the hollow duct cleaning tool is then placed over the screen housing opening of the clothes dryer, such that the distal end closely engages the clothes dryer to operatively air-seal the screen housing opening. The portable airstream appliance is then activated to direct the pressurized airflow through the duct cleaning tool, lint exhaust and ventilation system of the clothes dryer, thereby evacuating lint and debris collected inside the ductwork of the ventilation system.

(6) The term “pressurized airflow” refers broadly herein to either a positive laminar airflow or a negative laminar airflow (suction).

(7) The “portable airstream appliance” may comprise any standard electrical or gas-powered blower configured to generate a positive laminar airflow, or any standard vacuum appliance configured to generate a negative laminar airflow.

(8) According to one exemplary embodiment, the portable airstream appliance comprises an elongated hollow appliance tube.

(9) According to another exemplary embodiment, an adapter is located at the proximal end of the duct cleaning tool and is configured to removably attach the duct cleaning tool to the appliance tube of the portable airstream appliance.

(10) According to another exemplary embodiment, the duct cleaning tool comprises an elongated hollow air transfer tube extending between the open proximal and distal ends of the duct cleaning tool.

(11) According to another exemplary embodiment, the distal end of the duct cleaning tool is arcuately turned relative to a longitudinal axis of the air transfer tube.

(12) According to another exemplary embodiment, an exchangeable dryer interface is located at the distal end of the duct cleaning tool.

(13) According to another exemplary embodiment, the portable airstream appliance comprises a portable handheld blower configured to generate a positive airflow through the duct cleaning tool.

(14) According to another exemplary embodiment, the blower is configured to generate a flow rate greater than 500 CFM.

(15) According to another exemplary embodiment, the method includes evacuating the lint debris from the ductwork of the ventilation system at the remote discharge location.

(16) According to another exemplary embodiment, prior to locating the open distal end of the duct cleaning tool over the screen housing opening of the clothes dryer, a loose granular material is inserted through the screen housing opening into the ductwork of the ventilation system.

(17) In another exemplary embodiment, the present disclosure comprises a duct cleaning appliance adapted for cleaning a ventilation system of a clothes dryer. The ventilation system comprises ductwork communicating with a lint exhaust of the clothes dryer and extending to a remote

discharge location. The duct cleaning appliance incorporates a portable handheld blower and an attached duct cleaning tool. The handheld blower comprises an elongated hollow appliance tube, and a motor configured to generate a positive airflow through the hollow appliance tube. The duct cleaning tool is substantially hollow and has an open proximal end and an open distal end. The open proximal end is configured to removably connect the duct cleaning tool to the hollow appliance tube of the blower. The open distal end is configured to cover a screen housing opening at the lint exhaust of the clothes dryer. Upon locating the open distal end of the duct cleaning tool over the screen housing opening of the clothes dryer and activating the blower, pressurized airflow is generated and directed through the duct cleaning tool and lint exhaust of the clothes dryer thereby evacuating lint and debris collected inside the ductwork of the ventilation system.

(18) In yet another exemplary embodiment, the present disclosure comprises a duct cleaning tool configured for use in combination with a portable airstream appliance to clean a ventilation system of a clothes dryer. The ventilation system comprises ductwork communicating with a lint exhaust of the clothes dryer and extending to a remote discharge location. The duct cleaning tool has open proximal and distal ends and an elongated hollow air transfer tube extending between the open proximal and distal ends. The open proximal end is configured to removably connect the duct cleaning tool to the portable airstream appliance. The open distal end of the duct cleaning tool is configured to cover a screen housing opening at the lint exhaust of the clothes dryer. Upon (a) connecting the duct cleaning tool to the portable airstream appliance, (b) locating the open distal end of the duct cleaning tool over the screen housing opening of the clothes dryer, and (c) activating the portable airstream appliance, pressurized airflow is generated and directed through the duct cleaning tool, lint exhaust and ventilation system of the clothes dryer, thereby evacuating lint and debris collected inside the ductwork of the ventilation system.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

- (1) Exemplary embodiments of the present disclosure will hereinafter be described in conjunction with the following drawing figures, wherein like numerals denote like elements, and wherein:
- (2) FIG. 1 is a view illustrating a common stacked washer/dryer combination of the prior art;
- (3) FIG. 2 is diagrammatic view demonstrating airflow through a prior art clothes dryer and dryer ventilation system;
- (4) FIG. 3 is a perspective view of an exemplary duct cleaning tool according to one embodiment of the present disclosure;
- (5) FIG. 4 is an exploded view of the exemplary duct cleaning tool and handheld blower;
- (6) FIG. 5 is a further exploded view of the exemplary duct cleaning tool;
- (7) FIGS. 6 and 7 are views demonstrating application of the exemplary duct cleaning appliance (combined blower and tool) in the clothes dryer in an exemplary implementation of the present method;
- (8) FIGS. 8 and 9 are views showing the exemplary duct cleaning appliance operatively positioned on the clothes dryer during implementation of the present method;
- (9) FIG. 10 is a perspective view of an alternative exemplary duct cleaning tool according to the present disclosure;
- (10) FIG. 11 is an exploded view of the alternative duct cleaning tool and handheld blower; and
- (11) FIG. 12 is a further exploded view of the alternative duct cleaning tool.

DESCRIPTION OF EXEMPLARY EMBODIMENTS AND BEST MODE

(12) The present invention is described more fully hereinafter with reference to the accompanying drawings, in which one or more exemplary embodiments of the invention are shown. Like numbers used herein refer to like elements throughout. This invention may, however, be embodied in many

different forms and should not be construed as limited to the embodiments set forth herein; rather, these embodiments are provided so that this disclosure will be operative, enabling, and complete. Accordingly, the particular arrangements disclosed are meant to be illustrative only and not limiting as to the scope of the invention, which is to be given the full breadth of the appended claims and any and all equivalents thereof. Moreover, many embodiments, such as adaptations, variations, modifications, and equivalent arrangements, will be implicitly disclosed by the embodiments described herein and fall within the scope of the present invention.

(13) Although specific terms are employed herein, they are used in a generic and descriptive sense only and not for purposes of limitation. Unless otherwise expressly defined herein, such terms are intended to be given their broad ordinary and customary meaning not inconsistent with that applicable in the relevant industry and without restriction to any specific embodiment hereinafter described. As used herein, the article “a” is intended to include one or more items. Where only one item is intended, the term “one”, “single”, or similar language is used. When used herein to join a list of items, the term “or” denotes at least one of the items, but does not exclude a plurality of items of the list.

(14) For exemplary methods or processes of the invention, the sequence and/or arrangement of steps described herein are illustrative and not restrictive. Accordingly, it should be understood that, although steps of various processes or methods may be shown and described as being in a sequence or temporal arrangement, the steps of any such processes or methods are not limited to being carried out in any particular sequence or arrangement, absent an indication otherwise. Indeed, the steps in such processes or methods generally may be carried out in various different sequences and arrangements while still falling within the scope of the present invention.

(15) Additionally, any references to advantages, benefits, unexpected results, or operability of the present invention are not intended as an affirmation that the invention has been previously reduced to practice or that any testing has been performed. Likewise, unless stated otherwise, use of verbs in the past tense (present perfect or preterit) is not intended to indicate or imply that the invention has been previously reduced to practice or that any testing has been performed.

(16) Referring now specifically to FIGS. **1** and **2** of the drawings, in exemplary embodiments the present disclosure comprises a method for cleaning a ventilation system **10** of a conventional clothes dryer **12**—the ventilation system **10** connecting to dryer exhaust **13** and exhaust duct **14** and comprising standard metal ductwork **15** extending inside a building (e.g., apartment or condominium complex) and exhausting through an outside hooded vent **16**. The present method utilizes an exemplary duct cleaning tool **10** best illustrated in FIGS. **3**, **4** and **5** and described in further detail below.

(17) A conventional stacked washer/dryer set including washer “W” and clothes dryer **12** is illustrated in FIG. **1**. While specific steps of the present method are implemented in the context of clothes dryer **12**, it is understood that the teachings disclosed herein are equally applicable to any other stacked or stand-alone dryer appliance and that clothes dryer **12** is illustrated by way of example only. The present method may be implemented in other dryer appliances or other fixed or movable household units connected to ductwork **15** of a ventilation system **10**.

(18) Referring to FIGS. **1** and **2**, the exemplary clothes dryer **12** operates in a conventional manner understood in the art, and incorporates conventional parts, features and electrical controls. As shown diagrammatically in FIG. **2**, the clothes dryer **12** includes a generally cylindrical drum **21**, an electric motor **22** and belt **23** configured for rotating the drum **21**, an intake duct **25**, a heating element **26** communicating with the intake duct **25**, and a removable lint screen **28** located at the dryer exhaust **13**. The intake duct **25** defines an ambient air entrance at one end **25A** and is connected to a rear wall of the dryer **12** adjacent the drum **21** at an exit end **25B**. At exit end **25B**, conditioned (e.g., heated) air leaves the intake duct **25** and enters the clothes chamber of drum **21**. The heating element **26** resides between opposite ends of the intake duct **25**, and may incorporate a gas burner, electrical-resistance or other heating means. The exhaust duct **14** is connected to the

dryer exhaust **13** and communicates with an air handler **31** (e.g., electric blower or fan) of the dryer ventilation system **10**. The additional ductwork **15** extends from the air handler **31** through building walls **32** to the outdoor hooded vent **16**. In standard dryer ventilation systems, the ductwork has a minimum 4" inch diameter and is fabricated of rigid metal (e.g., galvanized or aluminum) in all concealed locations.

(19) During operation of the clothes dryer **12**, the air handler **31** draws ambient air into the entrance **25A** of intake duct **25** thereby generating a pressurized laminar airflow through the heating element **26** and outlet end **25B**, and into the clothes chamber of the rotating drum **21**. The heating element **26** heats the laminar airflow prior to entering the drum chamber. Within the heated chamber, accumulated moisture from damp tumbling clothes "C" is drawn outwardly by the air handler **31** through the removable lint screen **28** and dryer exhaust **13**. The lint screen **28** traps certain lint particles entrained in the heated airflow, while other lint and debris escape into the exhaust duct **14** and other ductwork **15** of the ventilation system **10**. After each use of the dryer **12**, the lint screen **28** must be removed from a screen housing **32** at the front bulkhead **34** of dryer **12** and then cleaned in order to help reduce the buildup of lint and debris within the ventilation system **10**. Once cleaned, the lint screen **28** is inserted back into the screen housing **32** through screen housing opening **35**. Lint and debris collecting inside the ventilation system **10** creates a fire hazard and may increase the time and energy required to dry laundry.

(20) In an exemplary embodiment, the present method utilizes a duct cleaning tool **50**, described further below, configured for use in combination with a portable handheld high-speed blower **51** (FIG. 4) to clean the ventilation system **10** of the clothes dryer **12**. The portable blower **51** may comprise any commercially available high-speed electric or gas-powered blower having an elongated hollow appliance tube **52** and motor **54** capable of generating a positive laminar flow rate of up to 500 CFM or more through the tube **52**. One commercially-available example of a suitable blower applicable in the present method is the Kobalt 140 MPH 80-Volt Max Lithium Ion (Li-Ion) Brushless Cordless Electric Leaf Blower manufactured and sold by LF, LLC, a Delaware limited liability company, having a place of business located at 1000 Lowe's Boulevard, Mooresville, North Carolina. This Kobalt blower produces up to 630 CFM.

(21) Exemplary Duct Cleaning Tool **50**

(22) Referring to FIGS. 3, 4 and 5, the exemplary duct cleaning tool **50** has a substantially hollow molded construction with open proximal and distal ends **61**, **62** and an elongated hollow air transfer tube **63** extending between the ends **61**, **62**. The open proximal end **61** incorporates an adapter **65** (or fitting) designed to frictionally attach the tool **50** directly to an end of the appliance tube **52** of handheld blower **51**, while the open distal end **62** is arcuately formed and comprises an exchangeable dryer interface **70**. The dryer interface **70** is attached to the tool **50** by fasteners **71** and is configured to closely engage the front bulkhead **34** of the dryer **12** at an opening into the clothes chamber of drum **21**. With the lint screen **28** removed from the dryer **12**, as demonstrated in FIG. 1, the dryer interface **70** of tool **50** operatively covers and air-seals the screen housing opening **35** at lint exhaust **13**. In the exemplary embodiment, the distal end **62** of the duct cleaning tool **50** is arcuately downwardly turned relative to a longitudinal axis of the air transfer tube **63**. Internal reinforcement ribs **69** may be integrally molded with the tool **50** proximate the curved distal end **62**.

(23) In the exemplary duct cleaning tool **50**, the dryer interface **70** is exchangeable with alternative attachments, such as shown in FIGS. 10-12, in order to accommodate the particular brand and style of clothes dryer **12**. Dryer interface **70** has a generally horizontal top wall **72** and a flat angled surround **74**. The top wall **72** comprises a thin solid structure configured to entirely cover the screen housing opening **35** at the front bulkhead **34** of the dryer **12**. The angled surround **74** of dryer interface **70** is integrally molded with the top wall **72** and defines an opening **75** shaped to substantially match a grill opening **76** (FIG. 7) formed at the lint exhaust **13** on a backside of the front bulkhead **35**. The obtuse angle of the surround **74** relative to the top wall **72** is approximately

100 degrees. The surround **74** provides fasteners points **78** through which the fasteners **71** are inserted to removably attach the dryer interface **70** at the arcuate distal end **62** of the duct cleaning tool **50**. The duct cleaning tool **50** is then frictionally attached to the appliance tube **52** of the blower **51** using adapter **65** as previously described.

(24) Referring to FIGS. **1**, **2** and **6-9**, to clean the dryer ventilation system **10** the user opens the pivoted dryer door **81** (FIG. **1**) and first removes the lint screen **28** from screen housing **32** through screen housing opening. With lint screen **28** removed, the user may deposit a small quantity loose granular organic material “M” into the screen housing opening **35**. As demonstrated in FIGS. **6-9**, the dryer interface **70** of the duct cleaning tool **50** is then placed over the screen housing opening **35** such that the top wall **72** of the interface **70** entirely covers and substantially air-seals the opening **35** at the front bulkhead **34** of the dryer **12**, while the angled surround **74** fits closely against the backside of the bulkhead **34** immediately adjacent the grill opening **76** of lint exhaust **13**. When the duct cleaning tool **50** is properly positioned, as shown in FIGS. **8** and **9**, the dryer interface **70** cooperates with the air transfer tube **63** to form an interrupted pathway for pressurized laminar airflow from the blower **51**. Upon activating the blower **51**, pressurized air (at a flow rate of up to 500 CFM or more) is generated and directed through the appliance tube **52** and duct cleaning tool **50**, and into the dryer ventilation system **10** through the lint exhaust **13**—best shown in FIG. **2**. Any lint or debris collected inside the ventilation system **10** is evacuated along with the loose organic material “M” through the exhaust duct **14** and other ductwork **15**, and outwardly from the building through the outdoor hooded vent **16**.

(25) A further embodiment of an exemplary duct cleaning tool **80** and dryer interface **81** applicable in the present method is illustrated in FIGS. **10**, **11** and **12**. The duct cleaning tool **80** is likewise configured for use in combination with a conventional portable handheld high-speed blower, such as blower **51'**, to clean the ventilation system of a clothes dryer. Like exemplary tool **50** previously described, the duct cleaning tool **80** has a substantially hollow molded construction with open proximal and distal ends **82**, **83** and an elongated hollow air transfer tube **84** extending between the ends **82**, **83**. The open proximal end **82** incorporates an adapter **85** designed to frictionally attach the tool **80** directly to an end of the appliance tube **52'** of handheld blower **51'**, while the open distal end **83** is arcuately formed. The dryer interface **81** is configured to closely engage the front bulkhead of the dryer at the opening into the clothes chamber of drum, as previously described. The dryer interface **81** has a generally thin and flat horizontal surround **91** with opposing downwardly turned longitudinal edges **92**, **93**, and defines a generally rectangular opening **94** shaped to substantially match the screen housing opening (not shown) formed at the front bulkhead of the clothes dryer. Molded fastener tabs **95** are integrally formed with the dryer interface **81** and receive respective fasteners **96** to removably attach the interface **81** at the distal end **83** of the tool **80**. Internal reinforcement ribs **99** may be molded with the tool **80** proximate the curved distal end **83**.

(26) In this exemplary embodiment, the dryer interface **81** of the duct cleaning tool **80** is placed over the screen housing opening (not shown) such that the surround **91** closely engages the front bulkhead immediately adjacent the screen housing opening and forms a substantially air-sealed pathway for passage of pressurized laminar airflow from the blower **51'**, through the tool **80** and into the ventilation system of the clothes dryer. This particular clothes dryer may not have a grill opening formed on the backside of the front bulkhead, but instead may have other perforated vent holes form in the bulkhead or rear wall of the metal drum. Prior to activating the blower **51'** and implementing steps of the present method, these perforated vent holes may be removably covered using a flat flexible magnet, adhesive tape, or other such means. Upon activating the blower **51'**, the duct cleaning tool **80** and attached dryer interface **81** operate in a similar manner described above to evacuate any lint or debris collected inside the ventilation system of the clothes dryer.

(27) In further alternative exemplary embodiments, the dryer interface may be any other suitable size and shape sufficient to effectively cover that portion of the clothes dryer immediately surrounding the lint exhaust. Many commercially available dryers have easily accessible lint

screens located the lint exhaust while others may be relatively hidden from view. Common locations for lint screens include just inside the dryer door, on the dryer back wall, on the top right corner of the dryer, and others.

(28) For the purposes of describing and defining the present invention it is noted that the use of relative terms, such as “substantially”, “generally”, “approximately”, and the like, are utilized herein to represent an inherent degree of uncertainty that may be attributed to any quantitative comparison, value, measurement, or other representation. These terms are also utilized herein to represent the degree by which a quantitative representation may vary from a stated reference without resulting in a change in the basic function of the subject matter at issue.

(29) Exemplary embodiments of the present invention are described above. No element, act, or instruction used in this description should be construed as important, necessary, critical, or essential to the invention unless explicitly described as such. Although only a few of the exemplary embodiments have been described in detail herein, those skilled in the art will readily appreciate that many modifications are possible in these exemplary embodiments without materially departing from the novel teachings and advantages of this invention. Accordingly, all such modifications are intended to be included within the scope of this invention as defined in the appended claims.

(30) In the claims, any means-plus-function clauses are intended to cover the structures described herein as performing the recited function and not only structural equivalents, but also equivalent structures. Thus, although a nail and a screw may not be structural equivalents in that a nail employs a cylindrical surface to secure wooden parts together, whereas a screw employs a helical surface, in the environment of fastening wooden parts, a nail and a screw may be equivalent structures. Unless the exact language “means for” (performing a particular function or step) is recited in the claims, a construction under 35 U.S.C. § 112(f) [or 6th paragraph/pre-AIA] is not intended. Additionally, it is not intended that the scope of patent protection afforded the present invention be defined by reading into any claim a limitation found herein that does not explicitly appear in the claim itself.

Claims

1. A duct cleaning appliance adapted for cleaning a ventilation system of a clothes dryer, the ventilation system comprising ductwork communicating with a lint exhaust of the clothes dryer and extending to a remote discharge location, said duct cleaning appliance comprising: a blower comprising an elongated hollow appliance tube, and a motor configured to generate a positive airflow outwardly through said hollow appliance tube; a hollow duct cleaning tool comprising an open proximal end and an open distal end, the open proximal end configured to removably connect said duct cleaning tool to said hollow appliance tube of said blower, and the open distal end configured to cover and operatively air-seal an entrance of a screen housing opening at the lint exhaust of the clothes dryer without inserting into the screen housing opening; whereby upon locating and operatively air-sealing the open distal end of said duct cleaning tool at the entrance of the screen housing opening and activating said blower, pressurized airflow is generated and directed through said duct cleaning tool and lint exhaust of the clothes dryer, thereby evacuating lint and debris collected inside the ductwork of the ventilation system.

2. The duct cleaning appliance according to claim 1, and comprising an adapter located at the proximal end of said duct cleaning tool and configured to removably attach said duct cleaning tool to said appliance tube of said blower.

3. The duct cleaning appliance according to claim 1, wherein said duct cleaning tool comprises an elongated hollow air transfer tube extending between said blower and the open distal end of said duct cleaning tool.

4. The duct cleaning appliance according to claim 3, wherein the distal end of said duct cleaning tool is arcuately turned relative to a longitudinal axis of said air transfer tube.

5. The duct cleaning appliance according to claim 1, and comprising an exchangeable dryer interface located at the distal end of said duct cleaning tool.
6. The duct cleaning appliance according to claim 1, wherein said blower is configured to generate a flow rate greater than 500 CFM.
7. A duct cleaning tool configured for use in combination with an airstream appliance to clean a ventilation system of a clothes dryer, the ventilation system comprising ductwork communicating with a lint exhaust of the clothes dryer and extending to a remote discharge location, said duct cleaning tool comprising open proximal and distal ends and an elongated hollow air transfer tube extending between the open proximal and distal ends, and the open proximal end configured to removably connect said duct cleaning tool to the airstream appliance, and the open distal end of said duct cleaning tool configured to cover and operatively air-seal an entrance of a screen housing opening at the lint exhaust of the clothes dryer without inserting into the screen housing opening; whereby upon connecting said duct cleaning tool to the airstream appliance, locating and operatively air-sealing the open distal end of said duct cleaning tool at the entrance of the screen housing opening and activating said airstream appliance, pressurized airflow is generated and directed through said duct cleaning tool and lint exhaust of the clothes dryer, thereby evacuating lint and debris collected inside the ductwork of the ventilation system.
8. The duct cleaning tool according to claim 7, and comprising an exchangeable dryer interface located at the distal end of said duct cleaning tool.
9. The duct cleaning tool according to claim 7, wherein the distal end of said duct cleaning tool is arcuately turned relative to a longitudinal axis of said air transfer tube.
10. The duct cleaning tool according to claim 7, and comprising an adapter located at the proximal end of said duct cleaning tool and configured to removably attach said duct cleaning tool to the airstream appliance.
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